

Matchlock drill
In the first of these pictures from a Dutch illustrated drill manual, the match in the musketeer's left hand is already lit. In the second, he pours gunpowder from a flask from his bandolier. He then rams down a musket ball, before preparing to pour priming powder into the pan, keeping the smouldering match at a safe distance between the fingers of his left hand.

After their victory over the Royalists at the battle of Naseby in 1645, New Model Army foot soldiers plundered the battlefield and deserted in large numbers to carry off their booty.

ARMY LIFE

To the civilian population any civil war army on the march was like a plague of locusts. The soldiers did not carry tents, so when away from permanent camp the alternative to sleeping under the open sky was to commandeer space in houses or barns. As well as accommodation, a local community might be expected to provide food. As armies struggled to keep their men supplied with basics such as biscuits, cheese, boiled beef, and beer, they resorted to "free quarter" – imposing troops upon civilians with the promise of future payment for food and lodging. Free quarter easily slipped over into straightforward armed robbery, as soldiers took whatever they fancied or needed. The horses required for cavalry and transport, for example, were often stolen. When the New Model Army mutinied in 1647, one of the men's principal demands was that they be given immunity from prosecution for horse thefts committed while in uniform.

The puritanical commanders of the New Model Army made vigorous efforts to alter the behaviour and attitudes of their soldiers. They tried to establish payment for provisions and put an end to looting. Preachers, who were considered a vital part of the army establishment, left men in no doubt of the future wrath God would visit upon the sinful. If this did not deter them, there were harsh punishments to focus their minds on virtue. For blasphemy, a man might have his tongue pierced with a red-hot iron. The punishment for desertion was hanging. Yet the New Model Army infantry continued to include, along with a solid core of committed, god-fearing men, a mass of unreformed reprobates. Suppressing the gambling, drinking, hunting, and whoring that made up the usual texture of camp life was an uphill struggle. Thousands deserted on the march, despite the death penalty, and the army readily employed deserters from the other side.



New Model Army cavalry armour
While musketeers usually fought without armour, the soldiers most likely to be struck by musket balls, the cavalry, wore iron breastplates and backplates. New Model Army cavalry had distinctive "lobster-tail" helmets.

INFANTRY TRAINING

Out of often unpromising material, the armies of the Civil War nevertheless succeeded in creating trained foot soldiers. One of the known advantages of a musket was that any fool could fire one with a little training; learning how to handle a pike was even simpler. The infantryman would belong to a company of perhaps 120 men at full strength, generally with two musketeers to every one pikeman. The soldier received systematic training – much of it recorded in contemporary drill books – in the handling of his weapon ("Posture"), and was taught how to operate in battlefield formation ("Motions" and "Evolutions"). Both muskets and pikes were collective weapons that made individual initiative worse than useless. Musketeers had to be disciplined to fight as a body, firing volleys as rapidly as possible in the general direction of the enemy. All foot soldiers were drilled to manoeuvre coherently in ranks and files.

> "MOSTLY YOUNG MEN AND BOYS ... WHO HAD LEFT THEIR TRADES TO FOLLOW WAR AND HAD BECOME ACCUSTOMED TO LEAD A LIFE OF DEBAUCHERY AND PILLAGE."
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> **CONTEMPORARY EYEWITNESS** DESCRIBING CONSCRIPTS IN THE NEW MODEL ARMY